

A Collection of
Private Devotions



The Rt. Rev. John Cosin

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1 Editor's Preface

This is a fun little project of transcribing some of the Rt. Rev. John Cosin's prayers. I've tried to make spelling consistent, and add helpful remarks (noted with *). Additional sections to break up the text are introduced as well. Likewise, erroneous capitalizations in the following are brought into conformity with our norms.

2 Preface

For the good and welfare of our souls, there is not in Christian religion any thing of like continual rule and force throughout ever hour of our lives, as is the ghostly exercise of prayer and devotion. Which the holy Apostles observing their Lord and Master to frequently to use, in the Morning (Mark 1:35) before day, in the Evening (Matthew 14:23) before night, and otherwise to spend the whole night in prayer (Luke 6:13), accounted it their duty also to be followers of his example and practice, as being a matter of high importance, and great benefit thereby to be obtained.

And therefore they addressed themselves to Him, desiring him to teach them how to pray, as S. John the Baptist had also taught his disciples. For which end and purpose, our Saviour taught and prescribed them a form of prayer so absolute and so perfect as never was like made before; which, from him who made it then, was ever afterward called the Lord's Prayer (Luke 11:2; Matthew 6:9).

A prayer, whereby we have not only Christ's name to countenance our suits, (in whole name if we wask anything, as we ought to do, he hath offered us in his holy Gospel, that we should obtain it [John 16:23];) but Christ's own word also, who himself is our Advocate (1 John 2:1), and being best acquainted with the laws and phrases of his Father's court, hath both for matter and form, drawn up such supplications for us as will be most available and prevalatn with Almighty God. And though Men should speak with angels tongues, yet words that sill be more pleasing to the ears of God than those which the Son of God did compose cannot possibly be uttered; nor can any prayers be so well frameda s those that are made by his blessed pattern.

It is for this cause called by the Father, The Prayer of all Prayers¹, and the rule or square whereby all our petitions are to be formed; having likewise been thus used in all ages of the Church, not only as a common part of her prayers and service, but as the chief and fundamental part of them, the ground whereupon she builds, the pattern whereby she frames, and the complement wherewith she perfects all the rest of her heavenly devotions, framing them as this is framed, with much efficacy, though not with superfluity of words.

Thus we begin at this day all our church services with the Lord's Prayer, and lay it as a foundation whereon to build the rest of our petitions that follow, sometimes continuing (as after the Creed) and sometimes perfecting (as after the Blessed Sacrament) our most holy devotions with it: thereby supplying with the fulness of that one, whatsoever may be defective in all other prayers, *praemissa legitima oratione* (saith Tertullian) *quasi fundamento accidentium*,

¹ Augustine, *Sermon 2 Post Pentecost*; Tertullian, *De Oratio*, ch. 9

etc. (*This is the law we go by, the groundwork and guide of all those holy prayers that Christians use to make*).

A part of which ancient piety are these daily devotions and prayers that hereafter follow; prayers which, after the manner and division of hours as they are², having heretofore been published among us by high and sacred authority, are now also renewed, and more fully set forth again, as for many other, so chiefly for these four reasons.

1. The first is, to continue and preserve the authority of the ancient laws, and old godly canons of the Church, which were made and set forth for this purpose, that men, before they set themselves to pray, might know what to say, and avoid, as near as might be, all extemporal effusions of irksome and indigested prayers, which they use to make, that herein are subject to no good order or form of words, but pray both what, and how, and when they list. Therefore among the ecclesiastical laws made in the time of Carolus Magnus [Charlemagne], we find this to be one; *orationes, quae ab Ecclesia probatae, non sunt rejiciantur* (let no prayer be used but those which are allowed by the church)³ [Likewise], *quascunque sibi preces aliquis describit, non eis utatur nisi prius eas cum instructoribus contulerit* (what prayers soever any man hath framed for himself, let him first acquaint those that are wise and learned with them, before he presumeth to use them)⁴.

And the reason is given in the 12th Canon of the Milevitan Council, which was also repeated in the 70th Canon of the Council of Alfric, *ne forte aliquid contra fidem, vel per ignorantiam vel per minus studium, sit compositum* (let either through ignorance, or through less care than is fit, any thing be said which is not consonant to the faith of Christ's Church).

And that men may not think these rules are to be applied to public prayers only, and not to private; let them weigh those words in the Council of Carthage, *quascunque sibi preces, etc.* (*the prayers which a man makes for himself, etc.*). And let them consider, that when Christ had bidden us to enter into our chamber and pray privately, presently he sets us a form to pray by even there in secret (Matthew 6:6, 9). By which passages those prayers are chiefly allowed and recommended unto us, (for all sudden and godly ejaculations are not to be condemned) which with good advice and meditation are framed beforehand by them that best know what belongs thereunto: That so through this means the worthiest part of our Christian duty to God-ward might suffer no such scandal and disgrace as otherwiles it is forced to do; and that when we speak to our call upon the awful majesty of Almighty God, we might be sure to speak in the grave and pious language of Christ's Church,

²*Horarium Regia autoritate editum*, etc. The Horary set forth with the Queen's authority (1560) and renewed (1573). Imprinted with privilege at London by William Seers.

³Microl. de Eccles. obser. cap. 4

⁴Council of Carthage, Can. 23

which hath evermore been guided by the Spirit of God and the Holy Ghost; and not to lose our selves with the confusion in any sudden abrupt or rude dictates, which are framed by private spirits and ghosts of our own. In regard whereof our very priests and deacons themselves are for their private and daily prayers enjoined to say the morning and evening devotions of the Church⁵; and when at any time they pray, or bid the prayers before their sermons, ther eis a set form of words prescribed for them to use⁶, that they also might know, it is not so lawful for them to pray of their own heads, or suddenly to say what they please themselves.

2. The second is, to let the world understand that they who give it out, and accuse us here in England to have set up a new Church and a new faith⁷, to have bandoned all the ancient forms of piety and devotion, to have taken away all the religious exercises and prayers of our fore-fathers, to have despised all the old ceremonies, and cast behind us the blessed Sacraments of Christ's Catholic Church: that these men do little else but betray their own infirmities, and have more violence and will that reason or judgment for what they say; the common accusations which, out of the avundance of those partial affections that transport them the wrong way, they are pleased to bring so frequently against us, being but the bare reports of such people as either do not or will not understand us what we are.

3. The third is, that they who are this may already religiously given, and whom earnest letts and impediments do often hinder from being partakers of the public, might have here a daily and devout order of private prayer, wherein to exercise themselves, and to spend some hours of the day at least (as the old godly Christians were wont to do) in God's holy worship and service; not employing themselves so much to talk and dispute as to practice religion, and to live like Christians: the continual and curious disquisitions of many unnecessary questions among us being nothing else but either the new seeds or the old fruits of malice, and by consequence the enemy of godliness, and the abatement of that true devotion wherewith God is more delighted, and a good soul more inflamed and comforted, than with all the busy subtilties of the world. In which sense Saint [Augustine] was wont to say, that the pious and devout, though unlearned, went to Heaven, while other men, trusting to their learning, disputed it quite away⁸.

4. The last is, that those who perhaps are but codly this way yet affected,

⁵Preface before the [Book of Common Prayer:] *All Priests and Deacons shall be bound daily to say the Mattins and Even-song, either openly or privately:* as it was of old ordained in the Council of Venice under Leo the First, Can. 14., and in the Council of Mentz, Can. 57

⁶Injunctions, capult. and Can. 55 in the Book of Canons and Constitutions Ecclesiastical.

⁷Sanders, [*De origine ac progressu schismatis Anglicani*;] Calvin. Turcis. [?;] Brist Demon. [?;] Certain [Articles] or forcible Reas. Art. 1. [;] and the common conceit of the most reluctatnt [Catholics].

⁸S. Aug. *Veniunt indocti & rapiunt coelum: & nos cum doctrinis nostris detrudimur ad infernum.*

might by others example be stirred up to the like heavenly duty of performing their daily and Christian devotions to Almighty God, as being a work of all others the most acceptable to his Divine Majesty.

In doing so we shall all give evident testimony to the world whose servants we are, and wherein our chiefest delight doth consist; we shall enjoy a perpetual communion with all the saints triumphant as well as militant, and we shall have just cause to conceive, that so much of our life is celestial and divine as we spend in this holy exercise of prayer and devotion.

3 The Compline

**First is read the following*

PSALM 132:4

I will not suffer mine eyes to sleep, nor mine eye-lids to slumber, nor the temples of my head to take any rest, until I find out a place for the habitation of the Lord.

ST. JOHN CHRYSOSTOM, I. *De Orando Deum*

Tell me, with what confidence canst thou lie down to sleep, and pass away the black darkness of night? With what fearful and ugly dreams shall thy soul (thinketh thou) be troubled, unless thou shalt first arm thyself against such delusions and fears, by strong and devout prayer? Let the wicked spirits find thee without such a guard, and presently thou becomest a prey unto them. Let them but spy thee at thy prayers, and presently, like frightened thieves, they ran away.

The Psalm

**Then is said the following Antiphon and Psalm*

The Antiphon: GOD be merciful unto us, and bless us: and shew us the light of his countenance and be merciful unto us.

Psalm 91:1-6: *Qui habitat*

To be said at this time according to the direction of the Rule of St. Basil

- 1 Whoso dwelleth under the defence of the Most High: *
shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty.
 - 2 I will say unto the LORD, Thou art my hope, and my stronghold: *
my God, in him will I trust.
 - 3 For he shall deliver thee from the snare of the hunter: *
and from the noisome pestilence.
 - 4 He shall defend thee under his wings, and thou shalt be safe under his
feathers: *
his faithfulness and truth shall be thy shield and buckler.
 - 5 Thou shalt not be afraid for any terror by night: *
nor for the arrow that flieth by day.
 - 6 For the pestilence that walketh in darkness: *
nor for the sickness that destroyeth in the noon-day.
- Glory be to the Father, and to the Son, *
and to the Holy Ghost.

As it was in the beginning, is now, and ever shall be: *
world without end. Amen.

The Lesson

**Then is read the following brief lesson*

1 PETER 5:8; 2 PETER 3:10-11

Be sober and watch, because your adversary the Devil goeth about like a roaring lion, seeking whom he may devour. And the day of the Lord will come as a thief in the night, in which the heavens shall pass away with a great noise, and the elements shall melt with fervent heat. Seeing then that all these things shall be dissolved, what manner of persons ought we to be in all holy conversation and godliness?

The Song of Simeon

**Then is sung or said the following Song of Simeon, or the Nunc Dimittis*

- 1 LORD, NOW lettest thou thy servant depart in peace: *
according to thy word.
 - 2 FOR MINE eyes have seen thy salvation: *
which thou hast prepared before the face of all people;
 - 3 TO BE a light to lighten the Gentiles: *
and to be the glory of thy people Israel.
- GLORY be to the Father, and to the Son: *
and to the Holy Ghost.
- AS IT WAS in the beginning, is now, and ever shall be: *
world without end. Amen.

The Creed

**Then is said or sung the Apostle's Creed*

I believe in God the Father Almighty,
maker of heaven and earth:

And in Jesus Christ his only Son our Lord,
who was conceived by the Holy Ghost,
born of the Virgin Mary,
suffered under Pontius Pilate,
was crucified, dead, and buried.
He descended into hell;
the third day he rose again from the dead;
he ascended into heaven,
and sitteth on the right hand of God the Father Almighty;
from thence he shall come to judge the quick and the dead.

I believe in the Holy Ghost;
the holy catholic church;
the communion of saints;
the forgiveness of sins;
the resurrection of the body,
and the life everlasting.
Amen.

Kyrie and Lord's Prayer

**Then is said the Kyrie and Lord's Prayer*

Lord, have mercy upon us.
Christ, have mercy upon us.
Lord, have mercy upon us.

Our Father, who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name;
thy kingdom come;
thy will be done;
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread.
And forgive our trespasses,
as we forgive them that trespass against us.
And lead us not into temptation;
but deliver us from evil. Amen.

**After which is said:*

THE DAY is thine, and the night is thine. Thou art worthy, O Lord, to receive honour, and praise, and worship for evermore.

The Prayers

**One or more of the following collects is said*

Merciful Lord, who of thine abundant goodness towards us, hast made the day to travel in, and ordained the night wherein to take our rest: grant us such rest of body, that we may continually have a waking soul, to watch for the time when the lord shall appear to deliver us from this mortal life. Let no vain or wandering fancy trouble us: let our ghostly enemy have no power over us, but let our minds be set wholly upon thy presence, so love, and fear, and rest in thee alone: that being refreshed with a moderate and sober sleep, we may rise up again with cheerful strength and gladness to serve thee in all good works, through Jesus Christ our Lord. Amen.

or

Lighten our darkness, we beseech thee O Lord, and by thy great mercy defend us from all perils and dangers of this night, for the love thy only Son, our Saviour Jesus Christ. Amen.

The Benediction

**The final blessing is then said*

God the Father bless me: God the Son defend me: God the Holy Ghost preserve me now and for ever. Amen.

4 Prayer at Bedtime

An admonition before we go to sleep

Permit me not sluggish sleep,
To close your waking eye,
'Till that with judgment deep
your daily deeds you try.
He that his sins in conscience keeps
when he to quiet goes,
More desperate is than he that sleep
amidst his mortal foes.

When we enter into our Bed.

In the name of the Lord Jesus Christ, who was crucified upon his cross and laid into his grave for me, I lay me down to rest. He bless me, keep me, and save me, raise me up again, and bring me at last to life eternal. Amen.

As we lay down to sleep

At night lie down,
prepare to have,
Thy sleep thy death;
thy bed thy grave.
Awake, arise;
think that thou hast
Thy life but lent,
thy breath a blast.

Final Prayers

**One or more of these final prayers is said before sleep*

I will lay me down in peace, and take my rest: for it is thou, Lord, only that makest me dwell in safety. Amen.

or

Have mercy upon me, O Lord, now, and at the hour of death. Amen.

or

O reserve me while I am waking, and defend me when I am sleeping, that my soul may continually watch for thee, and both body and soul may rest in thy peace for ever. Amen.